time. This would have cleared the way for new immigrants, who appear to have spread quickly through the subcontinent and then through to South East Asia. Some scholars believe that the indigenous tribes of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands may be remnants of the earliest migrations into the region.

One branch eventually reached Australia around 40,000 years ago and became the ancestors of the aboriginals. Genetic studies confirm that the Australian aboriginals do have a genetic link with aboriginal tribes in South East Asia. However, for a long time researchers could find no direct genetic link between present-day Indians and native Australians. Some scholars even argued that this group may have avoided India altogether and used a route through Central Asia. [16] A study published in 2009 by the Anthropological Survey of India finally found genetic traces to link some Indian tribes with native Australians. [17] Note that these are very tiny traces —966 persons from twenty-six tribes were tested but only seven individuals showed possible genetic links. Still, we have a possible solution to the puzzle. The researchers also suggested that the Indian and Australian groups had separated about 50–60,000 years ago.

Meanwhile, a sizeable population remained in the vicinity of the Persian Gulf and the subcontinent for several thousand years. Scientists think that many important genetic lineages emerged from this area at this time. During the relatively warmer inter-glacial periods, sub-branches would have spread farther out into Europe, Central Asia and so on. However, note that temperatures would have still been far lower than present-day levels and that there would have been several climatic cycles. This means that we are not dealing with a landscape that is static. Research into the Persian Gulf people is still relatively new and hindered by the fact that the area is now mostly underwater. Nonetheless, scholars like Jeffrey Rose are painstakingly reconstructing the history of what they call the ‘Gulf Oasis’.

This is a stylized and simplified account of what happened over tens of thousands of years. We are dealing with very tiny Stone Age bands of 50–100 individuals over vast expanses of time and space. Their movements